

bodies in my Stygian boat. To be sure, I was not happy to accept Heracles and Theseus and Pirithoüs when they came to these waters, although they were of divine descent and invincible strength. Heracles by his own hand sought and bound in chains the guardian dog of Tartarus and dragged it away trembling from the throne of the king himself. The other two attempted to abduct the queen from the chamber of Dis." (384–397) 10

The priestess of Apollo answered briefly: "No such plots this time; be not dismayed; our weapons bear no violence; let the huge doorkeeper howl forever and strike terror into the bloodless shades; let Proserpine remain safe and pure within the house of Pluto, her uncle. Trojan Aeneas, outstanding in goodness and valor, descends to the shades below to his father. If the sight of such great virtue and devotion does not move you, at least recognize this bough." (398–406)

She revealed the bough that lay hidden in her robe, and at this his heart that was swollen with anger subsided. Not a word more was uttered. He marveled at the hallowed gift of the fateful branch, which he had not seen for a long time, and turned his dark-colored boat around to approach the shore. Then he drove away the souls that were sitting on the long benches, cleared the gangway, and at the same time took the mighty Aeneas aboard; the leaky seams groaned under his weight and let in much of the swampy water. At last Charon disembarked the seer and the hero safe and sound on the further shore amid shapeless mud and slimy sedge. (406–416) 20

Huge Cerberus, sprawling in a cave facing them, made these regions echo with the howling from his three throats. When the prophetess saw his necks bristling with serpents she threw him a cake of meal and honey drugged to make him sleep. He opened wide his three throats in ravenous hunger and snatched the sop; his immense bulk went limp and spread out on the ground, filling the whole of the vast cavern. With the guard now buried in sleep, Aeneas made his way quickly over the bank of the river of no return. (417–425) 30

Immediately, on the very threshold, voices were heard and a great wailing and the souls of infants weeping who did not have a full share of sweet life but a black day snatched them from the breast and plunged them into bitter death. Next to them were those who had been condemned to die by a false accusation. To be sure, their abode has not been assigned without an allotted jury, and a judge, Minos, is the magistrate; he shakes the urn and draws lots for the jury, summons the silent court, and reviews the lives and the charges. Right next is an area occupied by an unhappy group who were guiltless but sought death by their own hand and hating the light abandoned their lives. How they wished now even for poverty and hard labor in the air above! But fate stands in the way and the hateful marsh binds them with its gloomy waters, and the Styx flowing round nine times imprisons them. (426–439) 40

Not far from here spread out in all directions were the fields of Mourning, as they are named. Here those whom relentless and cruel love had wasted and consumed hide themselves in secret paths in the woods of myrtle; even in death itself their anguish does not leave them. In this place he saw Phaedra, Procris, and unhappy Eriphyle displaying the wounds inflicted by a cruel son, and Evadne, Pasiphaë, and with them Laodamia and Caeneus, who had been changed into a boy and now once again was a woman. (440–449) 50

Here Aeneas meets Dido, queen of Carthage, who has recently committed suicide because of her love for Aeneas and his betrayal. He addresses her in sad, piteous, and uncomprehending tones; but she refuses to answer and turns away to join the shade of her former husband, Sychaeus.

From here Aeneas and his guide move on to the last group and farthest fields, reserved for those renowned in war, who had been doomed to die in battle and were much lamented by those on earth. Tydeus, Parthenopaeus, Adrastus, and many, many others come to meet Aeneas. Trojan heroes crowd around him, but the Greek warriors from Troy flee in terror. Aeneas converses with Deïphobus, the son of Priam who married Helen after the death of Paris. Deïphobus tells the story of his death at the hands of Menelaüs and Odysseus through the treachery of Helen. Their talk is interrupted by the Sibyl, who complains that they are wasting what brief time they have; it is now already past midday on earth and night is coming on (540–543):



Audio

This is the place where the road divides and leads in two directions: our way is to the right and extends under the ramparts of Dis to Elysium, but the left path leads to the evil realms of Tartarus, where penalties for sin are exacted.

We must look at Vergil's comprehensive and profound conception of Hell, Tartarus, and Paradise, Elysium or the Elysian Fields (548–579):

Suddenly Aeneas looked back to the left and saw under a cliff lofty fortifications enclosed by a triple wall around which flowed Phlegethon, the swift stream of Tartarus, seething with flames and rolling clashing rocks in its torrent. He saw in front of him a huge door, with columns of solid adamant that no human force nor even the gods who dwell in the sky would have the power to attack and break through. Its tower of iron stood high against the winds; and one of the Furies, Tisiphone, clothed in a bloody robe, sat guarding the entrance, sleepless day and night. From within he heard groans and the sound of savage lashes, then the grating of iron and the dragging of chains. Aeneas stood in terror, absorbed by the din. “Tell me, virgin prophetess, what is the nature of their crimes? What penalties are imposed? What is this great wail rising upward on the air?” (548–561) 10

Then she began to speak: “Renowned leader of the Trojans, it is not permitted for anyone who is pure to cross the threshold of the wicked. But when Hecate put me in charge of the groves of Avernus, she herself taught me the penalties exacted by the gods and went through them all. Cretan Rhadamanthus presides over this pitiless kingdom; he punishes crimes and recognizes treachery, forcing each to confess the sins committed in the world above, atonement for which each had postponed too long, happy in his futile stealth, until death. At once the avenging fury, Tisiphone, armed with a whip, leaps on the guilty and drives them with blows; as she threatens with her fierce serpents in her left hand, she summons the phalanx, her savage sisters. Then at last the sacred gates open wide, turning with strident horror on their creaking hinges. Do you see what kind of sentry sits at the entrance? What forms are watching in the threshold? The monstrous Hydra, more fierce than the Furies with its fifty black and gaping throats, has its home within. Then Tartarus itself yawns deep under the shades, extending straight down twice as far as the view upward to the sky and celestial Olympus.” (562–579) 20

In Tartarus Vergil places the Homeric sinners Tityus, Sisyphus, and possibly Tantalus; but there is difficulty in the text and its interpretation. Tityus, the son of universal Mother Earth, is the only one of the three named directly, and here is how the Sibyl describes his punishment (596–600):

“His body is stretched over nine whole acres and a huge vulture with its crooked beak tears at his immortal liver, forever renewed for the penalty of suffering. It digs deep within his breast to probe for the feast, giving no respite. As Tityus’ liver is restored, it is immediately devoured.”

Other criminals identified by Vergil are the Titans, who were hurled to the very bottom of Tartarus by the thunderbolts of Jupiter; the sons of Aloeus, Otus, and Ephialtes,¹⁴ who tried to storm heaven and seize Jupiter himself; Theseus and Pirithoüs; Phlegyas;¹⁵ and also Salmoneus, a son of Aeolus, who left Thessaly and founded Salmone in Elis. Salmoneus dressed himself as Zeus and imitated the god’s thunder and lightning by driving in a chariot with brazen vessels attached to it and hurling lighted torches until Zeus killed him with his thunderbolt. The Sibyl describes his crime and fate (585–594):

“I saw Salmoneus also being cruelly punished, who imitated the flames of Jupiter and the thunder of Olympus. He drove arrogantly through the Greek states and the city in the middle of Elis, riding in a chariot drawn by four horses, and he demanded that he be honored like a god. He was mad, because he tried to imitate the storm-clouds and the lightning that cannot be imitated with bronze and the clatter of horses’ hooves. But Jupiter, all-powerful, hurled his thunderbolt through the thick clouds and cast him headlong down with a violent whirlwind.”

Vergil only mentions Ixion. He is one of the more famous sinners condemned to Tartarus, who in other sources is punished by being bound to a fiery wheel that eternally revolves.

Vergil’s Tartarus is not a hell just for heroic sinners of mythological antiquity; in it all who are guilty suffer punishment. It is important to realize fully the ethical standards he applies. The nature of sin is clearly summed up by the Sibyl as she continues; just as clear is the moral conviction that assigns happiness to the good in the paradise of Elysium (608–751):

“Here are imprisoned and await punishment those who hated their brothers while they were alive or struck a parent and devised guile against a dependent or who hovered over their acquired wealth all alone and did not share it with their relatives (these misers were the greatest throng), and those who were killed for adultery or took up arms in an impious cause and were not afraid to betray the pledges made to their masters. Do not seek to learn the nature of the crime and fate of each and every sinner and the punishment in which he is submerged. Some roll a huge rock, others hang stretched on the spokes of a wheel; Theseus sits in his misery and will remain sitting forever; wretched Phlegyas admonishes all as he bears testimony in a loud voice among the shades: ‘Be warned! Learn justice and not to despise the gods.’ This one sold his country for gold, set up a tyrannical despot, made laws and revoked them for a price.



Audio

This one invaded the bedroom of his daughter in forbidden incestuous marriage. (608–623)

“All dared enormous crime and were successful in the attainment of their daring. I should not be able to recount all the forms of wickedness or enumerate all the names of the punishments if I had a hundred tongues and a hundred mouths.” (624–627)

After the aged priestess of Phoebus had uttered these words, she continued: “But come now, proceed on your way and accomplish the task you have undertaken. Let us hurry. I see opposite fortifications of Pluto’s palace erected by the forges of the Cyclopes and the vaulted arch of its door where we have been ordered to lay down this gift!” She had spoken, and making their way together through the gloom of the path, they hurried over the space between and approached the gates. Aeneas reached the entrance, sprinkled himself with fresh water, and placed the bough on the threshold. (628–636) 20

When this had been done and the gift had been given to the goddess, then at last they came to the happy places, the pleasant green glades of the Woods of the Fortunate, the home of the blessed. Here air that is more pure and abundant clothes the plains in soft-colored light and they have their own sun and their own stars. Some exercise their limbs on the grassy wrestling grounds, vie in sport, and grapple on the yellow sand. Others dance in a chorus and sing songs; and the Thracian priest, Orpheus, in his long robe, accompanies their measures on the seven strings of his lyre, plucking them now with his fingers, now with an ivory quill. Here is the ancient Trojan line of King Teucer, a most beautiful race, great-souled heroes born in better years, and Ilus, Assaracus, and Dardanus, the founder of Troy. (637–650) 30

Aeneas marvels at the unreal arms of the heroes and their chariots nearby. The spears stand fixed in the ground, and horses browse freely everywhere on the plain. The same pleasure that they had in their chariots and arms and in tending their sleek horses follows them after they have been laid in the earth. Behold he sees others feasting to the right and to the left on the grass and singing a happy paean in a chorus amidst a fragrant grove of laurel, from which the full stream of the Eridanus River rolls through the woods in the upper world.¹⁶ (651–659) 40

Here in a group were those who suffered wounds while fighting for their country, and the priests who remained pure while they lived, and the poets who were devout in their art and whose words were worthy of their god, Phoebus Apollo, or those who made life better by their discoveries in the arts and the sciences and who through merit made others remember them. All of these wore around their temples a snowy white garland; the Sibyl spoke to them as they surrounded her, singling out Musaeus especially: “Tell me, happy souls and you, O illustrious poet, what region, what place does Anchises inhabit? We crossed the great rivers of Erebus and have come on his account.” Musaeus replied in these few words: “No one has a fixed abode; we inhabit shady groves, living in meadows fresh with streams along whose banks we recline. But if the desire in your heart so impels you, cross over this ridge; I shall show you an easy path.” He spoke and walked ahead of them pointing out the shining fields below; then they made their way down from the height. (660–678) 50

Father Anchises was eagerly contemplating and surveying souls that were secluded in the depths of a green valley and about to enter upon the light of the upper air. It happened that he was reviewing the whole number of his own dear 60

descendants; the fate, fortune, character, and exploits of Roman heroes. When he saw Aeneas coming toward him over the grass, he quickly extended both his hands and a cry escaped his lips as the tears poured down his cheeks: "At last you have come, and your long-awaited devotion to your father has overcome the hard journey. Is it granted to me to see your face, to hear your voice, to speak to you as of old? I have been pondering your visit, thinking about when it would be, counting out the time, and my anxiety has not gone unrewarded. I receive you here after your travels over so many lands and so many seas, harried by so many dangers! How much I feared that Dido in her African kingdom might do you some harm!" (679–694) 70

Aeneas replied: "The vision of you in your sadness appearing to me again and again compelled me to pursue my way to this realm. My ships are moored on the Italian shore. Give me, give me your right hand, father, do not shrink from my embrace." As he was speaking, his face was moist with many tears. Three times he attempted to put his arms around his father's neck, three times he reached in vain as the phantom escaped his hands as light as a breeze, like a fleeting vision of the night.¹⁷ Meanwhile, Aeneas saw in this valley set apart, a secluded grove and the rustling thickets of a wood and the stream of Lethe, which flowed by the serene abodes. Around the river countless tribes and peoples were flitting, just as when bees settle on different flowers in a meadow in the calm heat of summer and swarm about the white lilies; the whole plain was filled with a murmuring sound. (695–709) 80

Aeneas, who did not understand, gave a sudden shudder at the sight; and seeking reasons for it all, he asked what the river was in the distance and what crowd of men filled its banks. Then father Anchises replied: "The souls to which bodies are owed by Fate at the stream of the river Lethe drink waters that release them from previous cares and bring everlasting forgetfulness. Indeed, I have desired for a long time to tell you about these souls, to show them before your very eyes, and to list the number of my descendants; now all the more may you rejoice with me that you have found Italy." "O father, am I to think that some souls go from here to the upper air and enter sluggish bodies again? What is this dread desire of these poor souls for light?" "To be sure I shall tell you and not hold you in suspense." Thus Anchises replied and proceeded step by step to reveal the details in order. (710–723) 90

"In the first place, a spirit within sustains the sky, the earth, the waters, the shining globe of the moon, and the Titan sun and stars; this spirit moves the whole mass of the universe, a mind, as it were, infusing its limbs and mingled with its huge body. From this arises all life, the race of mortals, animals, and birds, and the monsters that the sea bears under its marble surface. The seeds of this mind and spirit have a fiery power and celestial origin, insofar as the limbs and joints of the body, which is of earth, harmful, and subject to death, do not make them dull and slow them down. Thus the souls, shut up in the gloomy darkness of the prison of their bodies, experience fear, desire, joy, and sorrow, and do not see clearly the essence of their celestial nature. (724–734) 100

"Moreover, when the last glimmer of life has gone, all the evils and all the diseases of the body do not yet completely depart from these poor souls; and it is inevitable that many ills, for a long time encrusted, become deeply ingrained in an amazing way. Therefore they are plied with punishments, and they pay the 110

Ixion

Originally, the punishment of Ixion, son of Phlegyas, king of the Lapiths, was in the sky. He was the first to shed kindred blood. He invited his father-in-law Eioneus to come and collect the price that Ixion was to pay for his bride, Dia. Eioneus came but fell into a pit of burning coals that Ixion had dug and camouflaged. Since this was a new crime, no mortal was able to purify Ixion, and Zeus himself purified him, receiving him as a guest at his own hearth. Yet Ixion repaid him with a second crime, the attempt to violate Hera. Pindar describes the deception practiced by Zeus and the punishment of Ixion, bound to the wheel (Pythian Odes 2. 21–48):

They say that Ixion, upon the winged wheel that rolls in every direction, by the orders of the gods says this to mortals: "Pay back the one who does you good with gentle recompense." He learned this clearly. For he obtained a sweet life among the children of Cronus, yet he did not long enjoy happiness. For with mad thoughts he loved Hera, whom the bed of Zeus with its many pleasures had as his portion. But Pride urged him on to overbearing folly, and soon the man obtained a special woe, suffering what was reasonable. Two crimes bring him lasting labor: the first, because he was the first hero to shed kindred blood amongst mortals, not without clever planning; the second, that he made trial of the wife of Zeus in the deeply hidden marriage chamber. But his unlawful passion cast him into overwhelming evil when he approached the bed, since he lay beside a cloud, ignorant man, a sweet deception. For in appearance it was like the daughter of Cronus, the greatest of the daughters of the son of Uranus. The hands of Zeus put it there to deceive him, a beautiful cause of suffering. And he accomplished his own destruction, bound to the four spokes. Cast down in ineluctable fetters he proclaims his message to all. To him she [i.e., the cloud, Nephele] bore a monstrous child, alone, without the Graces, a solitary child that had no honor amongst human beings nor in the homes of the gods. This she nursed and named it Centaurus. And it mated with the mares in Magnesia, in the foothills of Pelion, and from them sprung a wondrous host, like both parents, below like their mother, above like their father.



Ixion. Attic red-figure vase by the Amphitrite painter, ca. 460 B.C. Ixion is naked, looking toward Hera (on the viewer's left), who is seated on her throne. Athena is on the right, holding the winged wheel on which Ixion will be bound. Ixion's left wrist is held by Hermes, and his right wrist by Ares. (© The Trustees of the British Museum/Art Resource, NY)

penalties of their former wickedness. Some spirits are hung suspended to the winds; for others the infection of crime is washed by a vast whirlpool or burned out by fire. Each of us suffers his own shade.¹⁸ (735–743)

“Then we are sent to Elysium, and we few occupy these happy fields, until a long period of the circle of time has been completed and has removed the ingrown corruption and has left a pure ethereal spirit and the fire of the original essence. When they have completed the cycle of one thousand years, the god calls all these in a great throng to the river Lethe, where, of course, they are made to forget so that they might begin to wish to return to bodies and see again the vault of heaven.” (743–751) 120

Anchises then leads Aeneas and the Sibyl to a mound from which they can view the souls as they come up, and he points out to them, with affection and pride, a long array of great and illustrious Romans who are to be born. The book ends with Aeneas and his guide leaving by the gate of ivory; why Vergil has it so, no one knows for sure:

“There are twin gates of Sleep; one is said to be of horn, through which easy exit is given to the true shades. The other is gleamingly wrought in shining ivory, but through it the spirits send false dreams up to the sky.” After he had spoken, Anchises escorted his son and the Sibyl and sent them out by the gate of ivory. Aeneas made his way to his ships and rejoined his companions. (893–899)

Vergil's Vision of the Afterlife

Vergil wrote in the second half of the first century B.C., and variations and additions are apparent when his depiction is compared to the earlier ones of Homer and Plato. There are, of course, many other sources for the Greek and Roman conception of the afterlife, but none are more complete or more profound than the representative visions of these authors. A comparison of them gives the best possible insight into the general nature and development of the ancient conception both spiritually and physically.

Vergil's geography of Hades is quite precise. First of all, a neutral zone contains those who met an untimely death (infants, suicides, and persons condemned unjustly); next the Fields of Mourning are inhabited by victims of unrequited love and warriors who fell in battle. The logic of these allocations is not entirely clear. Is a full term of life necessary for complete admission to the Underworld? Then appear the crossroads to Tartarus and the Fields of Elysium. The criteria for judgment are interesting; like many another religious philosopher and poet, Vergil must decide who will merit the tortures of his hell or the rewards of his heaven on the basis both of tradition and of personal conviction. Other writers vary the list. The Danaids, the forty-nine daughters of Danaüs who killed their husbands on their wedding night, are frequently added to the group in Tartarus; their punishment is that they must attempt in vain to carry water in containers that have no real bottoms. Some have observed that the tortures inflicted are often imaginative and ingenious, involving vain and frustrating effort of mind and body, and therefore characteristically Greek in their sly inventiveness. Perhaps so, but depicted as well is sheer physical agony through scourging and fire.

Attempts made to find a logic in the meting out of a punishment to fit the crime are only sometimes successful. Thus, for example, Tityus has his liver devoured because he attempted to violate Leto, since the liver was believed to be the seat of the passions.

Vergil's Paradise is very much an idealization of the life led by Greek and Roman gentlemen; and the values illustrated in the assignment of its inhabitants are typical of ancient ethics: devotion to humankind, to country, to family, and to the gods. In Elysium, too, details supplement the religious philosophy of Plato, which has been labeled Orphic and Pythagorean in particular and mystic in general. The human body is of earth—evil and mortal; the soul is of the divine upper ether—pure and immortal. It must be cleansed from contamination and sin. Once again we are reminded of the myth of Dionysus, which explains the dual nature of human beings in terms of their birth from the ashes of the wicked Titans (the children of Earth) who had devoured the heavenly god Dionysus. Presumably in the cycle of rebirth and reincarnation, the weary chain is ultimately broken; and we are no longer reborn into this world, but join the oneness of divinity in the pure spirit of the upper air.

Traditional Elements of Hades' Realm

Some identification and clarification of the various names and terminology linked with the Underworld are in order. The realm as a whole may be called **Tartarus** or **Erebus**, although these are also the names given solely to the region of torment, as opposed to **Elysium** or the **Elysian Fields**. Sometimes the realm of Paradise is located elsewhere in some remote place of the upper world, such as the **Islands of the Blessed**.

There are usually three judges of the Underworld: **Minos**, **Rhadamanthys** (or Rhadamanthus), and **Aeacus**. Their duties are variously assigned. Aeacus is sometimes relegated to more menial tasks; in comedy he appears as the gatekeeper. The rivers are generally five in number, with appropriate names: **Styx** (the river of hate); **Acheron** (of woe); **Lethe** (of forgetfulness); **Cocytus** (of wailing); **Pyriphlegethon** or **Phlegethon** (of fire). Acheron came to be used as a synonym for "hell" or "death." For philosophical and religious conceptions of the afterlife and the belief in the transmigration of souls and rebirth, the River of Forgetfulness (Lethe) assumes great importance. It was a custom to bury the dead with a coin in the mouth to provide the ferryman **Charon** with his fare.¹⁹ **Hermes Psychopompos** often plays the role of guide for the souls from this world to the next. The ferocious dog **Cerberus**, usually depicted with three heads, guards the entrance to the realm of the dead (see image on p. 370).

Hades, king of the Underworld, is also called **Pluto** or (in Latin) **Dis**, which means "the wealthy one." He is referred to either as a god of earth and fertility or as a deity rich in the numbers of those who are with him. The Romans called him and his realm **Orcus**, which probably means "the one or the place that constrains or confines." Sometimes Hades (this word may mean "the unseen one") is given no name at all or is addressed by some complimentary epithet, as is the custom with all dreadful deities or spirits—including the devil. Hades and his realm and its inhabitants are in general called *chthonian*,

that is, of the earth, as opposed to the bright world of the Olympian gods of the upper air; Hades himself may even be addressed as Chthonian Zeus. His queen is **Persephone**.

In Hades' realm, we may find either our heaven (Elysium) or our hell (Tartarus). Tradition developed a canon of mythological sinners who suffer there forever: **Tityus**, with vultures tearing at his liver; **Ixion**, bound to a revolving wheel; the **Danaids**, vainly trying to carry water in sievelike containers; **Sisyphus**, continually rolling a rock up a hill; and **Tantalus**, tantalized by food and drink. Tantalus' misery is vividly described in Seneca's play *Thyestes* (152–175).

The **Furies (Erinyes)** usually have their home in the realm of Hades; so does **Hecate**, who sometimes resembles them in appearance and in character. Hesiod, as we have seen, tells how the Furies were born from the blood that fell onto the earth after the castration of Uranus; according to others, they are the offspring of Night. Both versions are appropriate in terms of their sphere

The Universality of Greek and Roman Concepts

A consideration of how different societies and peoples at various times have viewed the afterlife cannot help but be fascinating. We all must die, and what will happen after death is a question that each of us has pondered deeply. Whatever our beliefs, the Graeco-Roman view must stand as one of the most philosophically profound and religiously archetypal, with themes that find parallels not only with religions of the West (such as Judaism and Christianity) but also with those of the East (Buddhism and Platonism share basic concepts).²⁰ For those who dismiss any certain knowledge of death's aftermath as futile, the artistic bequest of the ancient world can offer its own rewards.

The profundity and intensity of the Greek and Roman visions of an afterlife have been all-pervasive in the art and literature of Western civilization. The most explicit literary description is that of Vergil, and this has been the most potent inspiration for postclassical artists and writers. The great Italian poet Dante (1265–1321) was steeped in its radiance, which he suffused with Christian imagination and dogma. Dante takes Vergil as his guide through the *Inferno*, in which many of the classical features of Hades are to be found. In Canto 1 Dante, terrified and lost in a wilderness, encounters Vergil, who becomes his guide through Christian Hell; lines 82–87 express Dante's intense devotion to the Roman poet, inherent in the poem.

O, honor and light of all the other poets,
May the long study and great love
which made me pore over your tome
help me now.
You are my master and my authority,
You are the only one from whom
I drew and cultivated the noble style
which has brought me honor.

Many excerpts from Dante could be offered to show the myriad debts to the *Aeneid*. The depiction of Cerberus in Canto 6 is a particularly famous example (see image on p. 370).

and their powers. They vary in number, but they may be reduced to three with specific names: Allecto, Megaera, and Tisiphone. In literature and art, they are depicted as formidable, bearing serpents in their hands or hair and carrying torches and scourges. They are the pitiless and just avengers of crime, especially murder; blood guilt within the family is their particular concern, and they may relentlessly pursue anyone who has killed a parent or close relative. It has been conjectured that originally they were thought of as the ghosts of the murdered seeking vengeance on the murderer or as the embodiment of curses called down upon the guilty.

The Furies definitely represent the old moral order of justice within the framework of primitive society, where the code of “an eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth” is meted out by the personal vendetta of the family or the clan. This is Aeschylus’ conception of them in his dramatic trilogy, the *Oresteia*. The Furies persecute Orestes after he murders his mother (who has murdered his father), but eventually their role is taken over by a new regime of right: the Areopagus, the court of Athens, decides Orestes’ case through the due process of law; and it is significant that Apollo and Athena (the new generation of progressive deities) join forces with the justice of advanced civilization. The last play in the trilogy is called the *Eumenides*, which means the “kindly ones”; this is the name for the Furies as they were worshiped in Athens, after having finally been appeased and put to rest once and for all. The Furies also may be called the **Eumenides** in an attempt to ward off their hostility by a euphemistic appellation, as in the case of Hades.

The Christian concept of Satan should not be confused with the ancient portrayal of Hades, who is not fighting with his brother Zeus for our immortal souls. We all end up in his realm, where we may or may not find our heaven or our hell. The only exceptions are those who (like Heracles) are specifically made divinities and therefore allowed to join the gods in heaven or on Olympus. Hades, to be sure, is terrible and inexorable in his severity, but he is not in himself evil or our tormentor; we may fear him as we fear death and its possible consequences, which we cannot avoid. But he does have assistants, such as the Furies, who persecute with devilish and fiendish torments.²¹ Hades’ wife and queen of his realm, Persephone, is considered in Chapter 14.

It would be misleading, however, to conclude our survey of the Underworld with the impression that all Greek and Roman literature treats the realm of Hades and the afterlife so seriously. One thinks immediately of Aristophanes’ play *The Frogs*, in which the god Dionysus rows across the Styx to the accompaniment of a chorus croaking *brekekekex koax koax*; his tour of the Underworld is quite different from Aeneas’ and is at times hilarious.

The brilliant, satiric *Dialogues of the Dead* (e.g., nos. 18 and 22) by Lucian also illustrates the varied moods of the Greek and Roman portrayal of the Underworld.

For translations of Lucian,
see www.oup.com/us/morford.

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Primary Sources

Sources in the Chapter

Homer	<i>Odyssey</i> 11 (selections)
Plato	<i>Republic</i> 10.614b–end (the myth of Er)
Vergil	<i>Aeneid</i> 6

Additional Sources

Aristophanes	<i>Frogs</i>
Homer	<i>Odyssey</i> 24.1–24.204 (the shades of Penelope's suitors in the Underworld)
Lucian	<i>Dialogues of the Dead</i> (Loeb vol. 7)
Pausanias	<i>Description of Greece</i> 10.28.1–10.31.12: A lengthy description of Polygnotus' painting of the Underworld

In addition to the myth of Er, Plato presents several other visions of the afterlife and much discussion about the immortality of the soul.

Plato	<i>Apology</i> 40c–end
	<i>Gorgias</i> 522e–527e
	<i>Phaedo</i> 110b–115a
	<i>Phaedrus</i> 245c–257a
	<i>Republic</i> 386a–387d

Notes

1. Tiresias is the famous seer of the Theban cycle, who holds special prerogatives in the world of the dead. His wits are intact, and to him alone in death Persephone has left a mind for reasoning; all others are mere shadows (*Odyssey* 10. 492–495).
2. Another name for Hades' realm or part of it.
3. Elpenor can address Odysseus first without drinking the blood because his corpse has not yet been cremated.
4. As we learn in Book 10 (551–560), Elpenor got drunk and, wanting fresh air, left his companions in Circe's palace. He fell asleep on the roof; in the morning he was awakened suddenly and forgot where he was.

5. Tiresias does not have to drink the blood before he can speak, but he needs to drink it in order to express his prophetic powers to the full. He may also be drinking it as a mortal would drink wine, for refreshment, and thus he establishes ties of hospitality and friendship with Odysseus.
6. An early name of Delphi.
7. Tantalus' crime is variously described by later writers; whatever its specific nature, it is a crime against the gods, often identified as some abuse of their trust or hospitality. The verb *tantalize* comes from his name and his punishment. For Pindar's version, see pp. 437–439.
8. Plato's image is of a spindle with its shaft at one end and a fly or whorl at the other. We may liken this to an open umbrella held upside down and filled with eight concentric circular rings, which revolve and carry with them the stars and the planets.
9. This divinity (*daimon*) is the destiny that accompanies each soul through its life on earth, its good or bad *genius*.
10. In Hesiod (*Theogony* 713–814), Tartarus is a dark place in the depths of the earth into which Zeus hurled the Titans after he defeated them. It is surrounded by a fortification of bronze, and inside dwell Night and her children Sleep and Death. The house of Hades and Persephone is guarded by a terrifying hound. The river of Tartarus is the Styx, by whose water the gods swear dread oaths; if they break these oaths, they must suffer terrible penalties for a full nine years.
11. In graves in southern Italy and Crete have been found thin plates of gold inscribed with religious verses that were presumably intended to help the mystic believer in the afterlife. Some of the sentiments reflect the eschatology found in Plato, especially concerning the drinking of the waters of Lethe.
12. Vergil's conception of the rivers of the Underworld is far from clear. Charon seems to ferry the souls across Acheron, although Cocytus is mentioned in the immediate context; the Styx is identified by Vergil later. Tradition often has Charon cross the river Styx.
13. By poor, Vergil probably means that they do not have the fare to pay Charon. A coin was traditionally placed between the lips of the dead for passage to the Underworld.
14. The mother of the Aloadae was Iphimedeia, who said that their real father was Poseidon, according to the Greek version. These twins grew to be giants, and their attack on Zeus was made by piling Mt. Ossa upon Olympus and then Mt. Pelion upon Ossa. For this presumption, both were killed by Apollo while they were still young.
15. In some accounts Phlegyas is the father of Ixion; he burned the temple of Apollo at Delphi because of Apollo's affair with his daughter Coronis.
16. Near its source, the Po River flowed for some distance underground, and the legendary river of the Underworld, Eridanus, was identified with it.
17. Vergil echoes Homer's lines about Odysseus trying to embrace the shade of his mother.
18. That is, each of us has a soul that must bear the consequences of its life on earth.
19. For Charon in the Western tradition, see R. H. Terpening, *Charon and the Crossing: Ancient, Medieval and Renaissance Transformations of a Myth* (Lewisburg, PA: Bucknell University Press, 1985).
20. For the development of concepts of reward and punishment, see Jeffrey Burton Russell, *A History of Heaven* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1997), and, by the same author, *The Devil: Perceptions of Evil from Antiquity to Primitive Christianity* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1977). See also Alice K. Turner, *History of Hell* (Orlando, FL: Harcourt Brace, 1993). Alan E. Bernstein, *The Formation of Hell: Death and Retribution in the Ancient and Early Christian Worlds* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1995), reveals how Christianity, in developing its own particular views, chose between the two options offered by the Graeco-Roman and Judaic conceptions: all the dead live on with no distinction made between the good and the wicked, or the

good are rewarded and the wicked punished. Bernstein's discussion of "Christ's Descent into Hades" is relevant for its theme of the Harrowing of Hell or the Conquest of Death by both resurrection-god and hero, an archetype with which we have already become *very* familiar.

21. Zeus and the gods may destroy human beings and punish evil in this life, at times in opposition to one another. And the justice of the moral order of the Olympian gods and the Fates is the same as that of the realm of Hades. It is Prometheus who champions the human race as a whole against the antagonism of Zeus, but this is a quite different story.

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Orpheus and Orphism: Mystery Religions in Roman Times

A sudden madness took hold of the incautious lover—certainly forgivable, if the infernal world knew how to forgive. He stopped, unmindful of the condition, and overwhelmed by emotion he looked back at his Eurydice, who was at that very moment verging on the light. There all his labor was wasted and the agreement of the pitiless tyrant broken. Three times a shattering was heard throughout the Avernian fens . . . and Eurydice disappeared from before his eyes, scattered in different directions, like smoke caught in a gentle breeze.

—VERGIL, *Georgics* 4.488–500

Orpheus and Eurydice

Ovid tells the story of how Orpheus lost his new bride Eurydice (*Metamorphoses* 10. 1–85; 11. 1–66).



Audio

Hymen, god of marriage, wrapped in his saffron-colored cloak, left the wedding of Iphis and Ianthe and made his way through the vast tracts of air to the shores of the Thracian Cicones; he came at the call of Orpheus, but in vain, for although he was certainly present at the marriage of Orpheus to Eurydice, he did not smile or bless the pair or give good omens. Even the torch he held kept sputtering with smoke that drew tears and would not burn despite vigorous shaking. The outcome was even more serious than this ominous beginning. For while the new bride was wandering through the grass accompanied by a band of Naiads, she was bitten on the ankle by a serpent and collapsed in death. (10.1–10) 10

ORPHEUS' DESCENT TO THE UNDERWORLD

After Orpheus, the bard of the Thracian mountains, had wept his fill to the breezes of the upper world, he dared to descend to the Styx by the entrance near Taenarus so that he might rouse even the shades.¹



Spring: Orpheus and Eurydice, by Eugène Delacroix (1798–1863); oil on canvas, 1863; 78 × 65 ¼ in. Eurydice falls as a companion holds her and looks in horror at the snake gliding into the undergrowth at the bottom right corner. Orpheus with his lyre approaches from the left, and another nymph looks on in fear on the right, kneeling like the figure of Eurydice in Poussin's painting of the same subject. This painting, left unfinished at the artist's death, is one of a series of the four seasons with mythological subjects. (*Eugène Delacroix [Charenton Saint-Maurice, 1798–Paris, 1863]; The Spring—Eurydice bitten by a serpent while picking flowers [Eurydice's death]; 1856–1863; oil on canvas; 196 × 166 cm; Col.: MASP, Museu de Arte de São Paulo Assis Chateaubriand; photo by João L. Musa*)



Closer Look

Past the insubstantial multitudes of ghosts beyond the grave, he approached Persephone and her lord, who rule this unlovely realm of shadows, and sang his song as he plucked the strings of his lyre: “O deities of the world below the earth, into which all of us who are mortal return, if it is right and you allow me to utter the truth, laying aside evasion and falsehood, I did not come down to see the realms of Tartarus or to bind the triple neck, bristling with serpents, of the monstrous hound descended from Medusa; the cause of my journey is my wife; she stepped on a snake, and its venom coursing through her veins stole from her the bloom of her years. I wanted to be able to endure, and I admit that I have tried; but Love has conquered. He is a god who is well known in the world above; I suspect that he is famous even here as well (although I do not know for sure); if the story of the abduction of long ago is not a lie, Love also brought you two together. (10.11–29)

“By these places full of fear, by this yawning Chaos, and by the silent vast
ness of this kingdom, reweave I pray the thread of Eurydice’s destiny cut off too
soon! We pay everything to you, and after tarrying but a little while, we hasten
more slowly or more quickly to this one abode. All of us direct our course here,
this is our very last home, and you hold the longest sway over the human race.
Eurydice too, when she in her ripe age has gone through the just allotment of
her years, will fall under your power; I ask as a gift her return to me. If the Fates
refuse this reprieve for my wife, it is sure that I do not wish to return either. Take
joy in the death of us both!” (10.29–39)

As he made this plea and sang his words to the tune of his lyre, the blood-
less spirits wept; Tantalus stopped reaching for the receding waters, the wheel
of Ixion stopped in wonder, the vultures ceased tearing at the liver of Tityus, the
Danaid descendants of Belus left their urns empty, and you, O Sisyphus, sat on
your stone. Then for the first time, the story has it, the cheeks of the Eumenides
were moist with tears as they were overcome by his song, and the king who

**Orpheus Charms the Wild
Animals.** Mosaic from
Antioch (Antakya), second
century A.D. Orpheus,
dressed as a Thracian,
sitting on a rock, plucks
the lyre and by his music
pacifies the ferocious
beasts and birds. The
forest landscape is
indicated by the formal
tree in the upper right.
(Vanni/Art Resource, NY)



Closer Look

rules these lower regions and his regal wife could not endure his pleas or their refusal. They called Eurydice; she was among the more recent shades, and she approached, her step slow because of her wound. Thracian Orpheus took her and with her the command that he not turn back his gaze until he had left the groves of Avernus, or the gift would be revoked. (10.40–52)

ORPHEUS LOSES EURYDICE AGAIN

Through the mute silence, they wrest their steep way, arduous, dark, and thick with black vapors. They were not far from the border of the world above; here 50 frightened that she might not be well and yearning to see her with his own eyes, through love he turned and looked, and with his gaze she slipped away and down. He stretched out his arms, struggling to embrace and be embraced, but unlucky and unhappy he grasped nothing but the limp and yielding breezes. Now as Eurydice was dying for a second time, she did not reproach her husband; for what complaint should she have except that she was loved? She uttered for the very last time a farewell that barely reached his ears and fell back once more to the same place. (10.53–63)

At the second death of his wife, Orpheus was stunned. . . . The ferryman kept Orpheus back as he begged in vain, wishing to cross over once again; yet 60 he remained seated on the bank for seven days, unkempt and without food, the gift of Ceres; anxiety, deep grief, and tears were his nourishment as he bewailed the cruelty of the gods of Erebus. He then withdrew to the mountains of Thrace, Rhodope, and windswept Haemus. Three times the Titan sun had rounded out the year with the sign of watery Pisces, and Orpheus the while had fled from love with all women, either because of his previous woe or because he had made a pledge. Many women were seized with passion for union with the bard, and many in anguish were repulsed. He was the originator for the Thracian peoples of turning to the love of young men and of enjoying the brief spring of their youth and plucking its first flowers. . . . (10.64; 10.72–85) 70

THE DISMEMBERMENT OF ORPHEUS

While the Thracian bard was inducing the woods, the rocks, and the hearts of the wild beasts to follow him, Ciconian women, their frenzied breasts clad in animal skins, spied Orpheus from the top of a hill as he was singing to his lyre. One of them, her hair tossing in the light breeze, exclaimed: “Ah look, here is the one who despises us.” And she hurled her weapon, wreathed with foliage, straight at the face of Apollo’s son as he sang, and it made its mark but did not wound. The weapon of another was a stone, which as it hurtled was overcome in midair by the harmony of voice and lyre and fell prone at his feet like a suppliant apologizing for so furious an assault. But their hostility grew more bold, and restraint was abandoned until the Fury of madness held absolute sway. All 80 weapons would have been softened by his song, but the great clamor, the Phrygian flutes with their curved pipes, the drums, the pounding, and the Bacchic shrieks drowned out the sound of his lyre. (11.1–18)

Then at the last the stones that could not hear grew red with the blood of the poet. But first the maenads seized the hordes of birds still spellbound by the singer’s voice, the serpents, and the throng of beasts, all testimonies to the triumph of his song. And then they turned with bloody hands on Orpheus himself, like birds that throng together if at any time they see the owl of night abroad by



Audio

day. They made for the bard, just as the stag about to die is prey for the dogs in the morning sand of the amphitheater, and they flung the verdant leafy thyrsus, not made for such deadly purpose. Some hurled clods of earth, others branches ripped from trees, still others stones. (11.18–30) 90

So that weapons might not be wanting for their fury, it happened that oxen were working the earth, yoked to the ploughshare; and nearby sturdy farmers were digging the hard fields with much sweat preparing for the harvest. When they saw the throng, they fled leaving behind the tools with which they worked. Hoes, heavy mattocks, and long rakes lay scattered through the empty fields. The madwomen snatched them up; and after they had torn apart the oxen that threatened with their horns, they rushed back again to mete out the poet's fate. In their sacrilege, they destroyed him as he stretched out his hands and spoke then for the first time in vain with a voice that touched no one. And through that mouth, which was heard, god knows, by stones and understood by bestial senses, his soul breathed forth receding on the winds. (11.30–43) 100

For you, O Orpheus, for you the trees let fall their leaves and shorn of foliage made lament. They say too that rivers swelled with their own tears, and the Naiads and Dryads changed their robes to black and wore their hair disheveled. His limbs lie scattered in various places; his head and lyre you got, O river Hebrus; and—O wonder—while they floated in midstream, the lyre made some plaintive lamentation, I know not what; the lifeless tongue murmured laments too, and the banks lamented in reply. And then they left his native Thracian river and were carried out to sea, until they reached Methymna on the island of Lesbos. Here they were washed ashore on foreign sands, and a savage snake made for the mouth and hair soaked with the dripping foam. At last Phoebus Apollo appeared and stopped the serpent as it prepared to make its bite and froze hard its open mouth and gaping jaws, just as they were, in stone. (11.44–60) 110

The shade of Orpheus went down below the earth and recognized all the places he had seen before; he looked amid the fields of the pious and found Eurydice, and clasped her in his eager arms. Here now they walk together side by side, sometimes he follows her as she precedes, sometimes he goes ahead and safely now looks back at his Eurydice. (11.61–66) 120

As Ovid continues the story, we learn that Bacchus was distressed at the loss of the poet who sang his mysteries; he punished the Thracian women by turning them into trees and then abandoned Thrace all together.

The other major classical version of the story of Orpheus and Eurydice is Vergil's (*Georgics* 4. 452–526). Most, but not all, of the details are similar, although the poetic timbre is different. According to Vergil, Eurydice stepped on the snake while running away from the unwelcome advances of Aristaeus, son of Apollo and Cyrene.² Thus Ovid and Vergil represent the tradition for the tragic love story of Orpheus and Eurydice: a paean to the devotion of lover and beloved, husband and wife. Their eternal myth has been re-created again and again with imagination, beauty, and profundity, whether it be in an opera by Gluck or a movie by Cocteau. Orpheus has become the archetype of the poet and musician, and of the great and universal power of art.

A burning question fascinates us all: "Why did Orpheus look back?" Ovid is quite explicit as we have just seen: "frightened that she might not be well and yearning to see her with his own eyes, through love he turned and looked, and with his gaze she slipped away and down." In Vergil's poetry (*Georgics* 4. 486–492),

For a translation of Vergil, see www.oup.com/us/morford.

similarly at the verge of reaching the upper air, “a sudden frenzy seized the unwary lover—worthy of pardon, except by the pitiless Underworld—he stopped, and unmindful, alas, and overcome in spirit, looked back at his own Eurydice. Then and there all his labor was spent in vain.” To explore the variations wrought by countless artists over the centuries in their interpretation of Orpheus’ tragic decision is fascinating. In many subsequent versions, Eurydice herself, unaware of the pact that Orpheus has sworn and unable to understand the cold cruelty of her beloved husband who will not turn to give her comfort, assails him with desperate and anguished pleas. Overcome by her remorse, Orpheus relents. As some believe, at that dread and irrevocable moment, the master musician lost faith in the power of his art. Had the gods imposed a condition that they knew he could never fulfill?

Life of Orpheus, Religious Poet and Musician

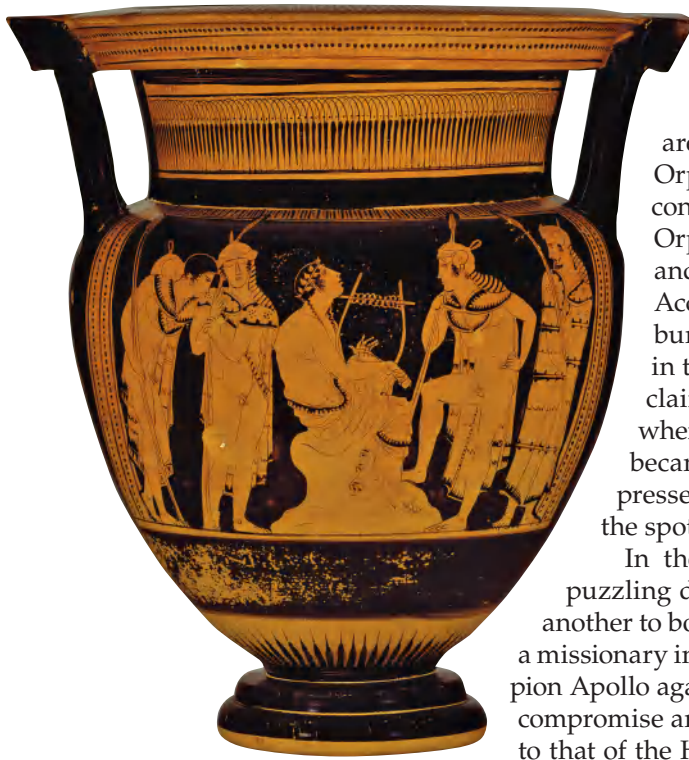
There is another very important side to Orpheus’ character, of which we can only catch glimpses today because of the inadequacy of our evidence. He was considered the founder of a religion, a prophet, who with his priests and disciples committed to writing holy words that provided a bible for dogma, ritual, and behavior. Variations and inconsistencies in the tradition make it difficult to know this Orpheus and his religion precisely, but the general nature of their character and development can be discerned, despite the frustrating contradictions and obscurities.³ Some of the significant “facts” that can be isolated from the diverse accounts are as follows.

Orpheus’ home was in Thrace; his mother was one of the Muses, usually said to be Calliope; his father was either Oeagrus, a Thracian river-god, or the great god Apollo, whom he followed. He wooed and won Eurydice, a Dryad, by the charm of his music. When she died, he went to Hades to fetch her but failed. Orpheus was one of the members of Jason’s Argonautic expedition.⁴ He had a son or a pupil, **Musaeus**, who assumed many of the characteristics of Orpheus himself. Among the versions of his death, several prove interesting in the quest for the historical religious teacher. He is said to have been struck down by the thunderbolt of Zeus because in his mysteries he taught things unknown before; he also is said to have died through a conspiracy of his countrymen, who would not accept his teachings.

The common tradition (which both Ovid and Vergil reflect) makes the women of Thrace responsible for his death. But the reasons for their hostility



Orpheus, Eurydice, and Hermes. Marble relief, Roman copy of a Greek original of the fifth century B.C.; height 46 ½ in. This panel was originally part of a parapet placed around the Altar of the Twelve Gods in the Agora at Athens. It shows the moment when Orpheus has looked back at Eurydice and they part forever. Hermes Psychopompos has his hand on Eurydice's wrist, ready to lead her back to the Underworld—a poignant contrast with the tender placement of Eurydice's left hand on her husband's shoulder. The names of the figures appear above them, Orpheus' being written right to left. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)



Orpheus among the Thracians. Athenian red-figure krater by the Orpheus painter, ca. 440 B.C. Orpheus, seated on a rock and garlanded with ivy, sings with the accompaniment of his seven-stringed lyre to a group of four Thracians, dressed in their native cloaks and fox-skin headwear. They are enchanted. (*Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY*)

vary: they were angry because he neglected them after the death of Eurydice, or refused to initiate them into his mysteries, or enticed their husbands away from them. Sometimes the women are followers of Dionysus, expressly directed against Orpheus by their god: Dionysus, in his attempts to convert Thrace to his religion, met the opposition of Orpheus, a devoted follower of Apollo the sun-god, and so sent his maenads to tear the bard to pieces. According to some, the fragments of his body were buried by his mother and sister Muses in Thrace or in the region of Mt. Olympus. His head and lyre were claimed by Lesbos (as already explained by Ovid), where a shrine was erected in his honor. His head became an oracular source, but its prophecies were suppressed by Apollo. A temple of Bacchus was built over the spot where the head was buried.⁵

In these conflicting speculations, a fundamental and puzzling duality is evident. Orpheus is linked in one way or another to both Apollo and Dionysus. Was there a *real* Orpheus, a missionary in Thrace who met his death violently? Did he champion Apollo against Dionysus or Dionysus against Apollo? Did he compromise and adapt the religion of the Near Eastern Dionysus to that of the Hellenic Apollo, taking from both and preaching a message that was new and convincing, at least to some?

However one would like to interpret the evidence, this duality cannot be ignored. On one hand, the music, magic, and prophecy suggest Apollo, as does the championship of civilization, but Orpheus' sermon of gentleness and peace has none of the violence of the archer-god. On the other hand, Orpheus' music is the antithesis of the clashing din of Bacchus; and the tales of his misogyny could imply a religion that at some period was confined to men, in contrast to the worship of Dionysus with its appeal to women. At the same time, Orphic initiation and mysteries are by their very nature Dionysiac. Other elements in the legends of both Orpheus and Dionysus are strikingly parallel: Orpheus is torn to pieces like Dionysus himself (at the hands of the Titans), or like Pentheus, who also opposed the god and met destruction at the hands of his maenads. Like Orpheus, Dionysus descended to the Underworld, in his case to fetch his mother, Semele. Indeed, a less common variant has Orpheus successful (like Dionysus) in his pursuit of Eurydice.⁶

There is nevertheless a well-established tradition that the historic Orpheus was not a god but a hero who lived, suffered, and died; his tomb was sacred, and he had a cult. He was in this view a prophet, a priest, or, if you like, a saint, whose god was Apollo or Dionysus, or both. Such a belief is ultimately subjective; but by the fifth century B.C., he *was* accepted as a human religious teacher, whose doctrine was communicated in sacred writings attributed to him and believed to be much earlier in time. Tablets were said to be found in the mountains of Thrace inscribed with his writing, prescribing potent charms, incantations, and spells. In the fourth century, Plato quotes hexameter lines of Orpheus and tells of priests who preached his message of salvation. Later, Orpheus is credited with songs about the gods and the origin of all things. The hymns that have come down to us under Orpheus' name were given their present form in the early centuries of

Orpheus—The Immortal Artist

Orpheus exemplifies the universal power of the artist and in particular music and poetry. Art eases care, makes life meaningful and beautiful, and can instruct. Orpheus is also the archetypal religious teacher, illustrating the omnipotence of the word in music. Orpheus suffers and dies the martyr's death of a prophet and a savior. Just as potent are the eternal elements in the romance of Orpheus and Eurydice. Theirs is a moving and tragic love story that, in its endless metamorphoses, never fails to touch the hearts and minds of human beings of all times.

There is a wondrous duality of religion and music in the archetype that illuminates the uplifting and informing spiritual power of his gift. "Indeed, what then is music? Music is a sacred art, which brings together all who have spirit, like cherubim around a radiant throne, and that is why it is the holiest among the arts, sacred music."⁷

The following simple but sublime verses from Shakespeare's *Henry VIII*, act 3, scene 3, which also sum up the spiritual power of Orpheus, have often been set to music. A beautiful version is that of William Schuman:

Orpheus with his lute made trees,
And the mountains that freeze
Bow themselves when he did sing.
To his music plants and flowers
Ever sprung, as sun and showers
There had made a lasting spring.

Every thing that heard him,
Even the billows of the sea,
Hung their heads and then lay by.
In sweet music is such art,
Killing care and grief of heart.
Fall asleep, or hearing, die.

our era;⁸ in fact, this corpus of *Orphic Hymns* may have been composed (rather than compiled) in the second or third century A.D. It is of little help for reconstructing early Orphic doctrine.⁹

In music, art, and poetry, Orpheus has been a source of inspiration for thousands of works. His myths address several of the most profound of human concerns: the power of music over animals and inanimate nature, over human discord, and over death itself; the pain of bereavement and the hope of reunion after the loss of one's beloved.

The Orphic Bible

Dominant in the pantheon of Orphism was Dionysus, very often under the name of **Zagreus**. Although we hear about initiation into mysteries and a ritual life of purity demanded by the Orphics, we do not know their details. The shedding of

blood and the eating of flesh seem to have been important prohibitions inspired by a fundamental belief in the transmigration of the soul and the sanctity of all life. It is possible to reconstruct the basic themes of the Orphic theogony, with its myth of Dionysus crucial to the doctrine. Although parallels to the *Theogony* of Hesiod are apparent, there are meaningful differences and variations. The major stages in the Orphic theogony run as follows, although there are many versions and contradictions in the tradition.

The first principle was **Chronus** (Time), sometimes described as a monstrous serpent having the heads of a bull and a lion with a god's face between. Chronus was accompanied by brooding Adrasteia (Necessity), and from Chronus came Aether, Chaos, and Erebus. In Aether (the bright upper air), Chronus fashioned an egg that split in two; and from this appeared the first-born of all the gods, **Phanes**, the creator of everything, called by many names, among them Eros.¹⁰ He was a bisexual deity, with gleaming golden wings and four eyes, described as possessing the appearance of various animals. Phanes bore a daughter, Night, who became his partner in creation and eventually his successor in power. Night then bore Gaea (Earth) and Uranus (Heaven), and they produced the Titans. Next Cronus succeeded to the rule of Night, and subsequently (as in the Hesiodic account) Zeus wrested power from his father, Cronus.

Then Zeus swallowed Phanes, and with him all previous creation (including a special race of human beings of a golden age); Zeus now created everything anew, with the help of Night. As a second creator, Zeus became the beginning and middle and end of all things. Eventually, Zeus mated with Kore (Persephone), and Dionysus was born. This myth of the birth of Dionysus is most potent for the dogma it provides, and we have related it in connection with Dionysus himself (p. 322). Its essential features are that the infant god was dismembered and devoured by the monstrous Titans, who were then struck down in punishment by the thunderbolt of Zeus. From the ashes of the Titans came mortals; thus humans are partly evil and mortal but also partly pure and divine, since the wicked Titans had consumed the god, although not completely. The heart of Dionysus was saved and he was born again.

In this way, the Orphic bible provided the divine authority for belief in an immortal soul; the necessity for keeping this soul pure despite the contamination and degradation of the body; the concept of a kind of original sin; the transmigration of the soul to an afterlife of reward or punishment; and finally, after various stages of purification, an apotheosis, a union with the divine spirit in the realms of the upper aether. The seeds of everything came from Phanes or Zeus; out of the One, all things come to be, and into the One they are once again resolved.

Plato's myth of Er and Vergil's vision of the afterlife are, as far as we can tell, strongly influenced by Orphic concepts; a reading of both, translated in Chapter 15, conveys most simply and directly a feeling for the basic tenets of Orphism. The ritual purification and catharsis of the great god Apollo are mingled with the Dionysiac belief in the ultimate immortality of the human soul to provide a discipline and control of the ecstatic passion of his Bacchic mysteries.

There are parallels between characteristics of Orpheus and his religion and that of a **shaman** and **shamanism**. Shamanism is a religious belief system of great antiquity and was practiced in many northern Asian and native North American cultures. A shaman is one who has been called to a spiritual life and who undergoes a period of solitary training and fasting to emerge as a

mystical figure with supernatural powers. Shamans are said to enter trance-like states, which include the undertaking of journeys into the spirit realm. Through this unique access to the spirit world, a shaman claims to return from his spirit journey with special powers of divination and healing. He becomes the wise teacher, revealing his wisdom in religious poetry, and a man of god, preaching doctrine and worship. Orpheus shares many traits with traditional shamans, including such attributes as the ability to bewitch birds and beasts, to travel to the Underworld, and to deliver oracles after his death, through his magical, singing head.¹¹

Mystery religions have been a persistent theme; their spiritual essence has been associated with Eros, Rhea, Cybele and Attis, Aphrodite and Adonis, Dionysus, Demeter, and Orpheus. We cannot distinguish with clear precision among the many different mystery religions and philosophies of the ancient world. It is possible, for example, to argue that the mysteries of Demeter, with their emphasis on participation in certain dramatic rites, lacked the spiritual depth of Orphism, with its insistence on the good life as well as mere initiation and ritual. In any comparison or contrast for the greater glory or detriment of one god or goddess and one religion as opposed to another, it must be remembered that we know practically nothing about the Greek and Roman mysteries. In contrast, our knowledge, say, of Christianity, particularly in its full development, is infinitely greater.

The correspondences between Christianity and the other mystery religions of antiquity are perhaps more startling than the differences. Orpheus and Christ share attributes in the early centuries of our era;¹² and of all the major ancient deities, Dionysus has most in common with the figure of Christ. It was the son of Apollo, however, Asclepius, the kindly healer and miracle worker, who posed the greatest threat to early Christianity (see pp. 262–263).

Mystery Religions in Roman Times

Indeed, the association of Christ with the vine frequently led to the use of the myths and attributes of Dionysus in early Christian iconography. We can see this influence in a wall mosaic (third century A.D.) in the cemetery beneath St. Peter's basilica in the Vatican (see the image on p. 267). In both cases, the vine of Dionysus, the symbol of new life after release from the old life, is associated with the Christian resurrection and the words of Jesus in John 15:1, "I am the true vine." In the same cemetery, there is a tomb containing both pagan and Christian burials, one of which is a second-century sarcophagus decorated with a relief showing Dionysus finding Ariadne (see p. 597). Whether or not the occupant of the sarcophagus was Christian, the finding of Ariadne as she wakes from sleep, by the god of life renewed, is an allegory of the soul waking from death equally applicable to the Christian doctrine of the resurrection or to pagan beliefs in an afterlife. The mysteries of Dionysus were widely practiced, and the similarities between them and the Christian *mythoi* made the process of **syncretism** inevitable. The term *syncretism* literally means "growing together," and in the context of religion and mythology it describes the harmonizing of different cults and their myths into some sort of unity. You can clearly see this process in our discussion of the worship of Isis later in this chapter.

Mystery religions were widely practiced in the Roman Empire during the first four centuries of the Christian era.¹³ Like Christianity, they gave the individual worshiper hope for a better life in an uncertain world and frequently the expectation of a new life after death. Since mystery religions involved initiation into secret knowledge, our information about them is at best partial and generally inadequate. We can say with certainty that the mysteries involved a sense of belonging to a group and that initiation preceded some sort of revelation, which resulted in a sense of release and joy, with hope for a better future in this life and in the life after death. Often the initiate submitted to the discipline of a rule of life, so that morality and religion were closely associated.

The mysteries of Demeter at Eleusis (discussed at length in Chapter 14) attracted initiates from all classes all over the empire and continued to be practiced down into late antiquity. The sanctuary was destroyed by the Huns in A.D. 395, and the Christians saw to it that it was never rebuilt.

Other Mystery Religions

Cybele and Attis. The mysteries of Cybele and Attis continued to be important throughout the Roman world, but their violent elements, especially the self-mutilation of the Galli (i.e., priests), made the cult less attractive than other cults with central resurrection myths (see p. 685). Shedding the blood of a bull came to be a spectacular feature of the rite of initiation into these mysteries. It was called the **taurobolium**, and the initiate stood in a pit under the bull, so that its blood poured down upon him.¹⁴ This baptism symbolized purification, the washing away of the old life, and resurrection to a new one; and the rebirth was further symbolized by the drinking of milk, the drink of a newborn child, while the ancient musical instruments of Cybele's worship became part of a kind of communion: "I have eaten from the tambourine, I have drunk from the cymbal, I have become a mystic of Attis," are the words of one hymn. Like the Eleusinian mysteries, the mysteries of Cybele ceased to be practiced after the fourth century.

The Cabiri. The oldest of the Greek mysteries after those of Demeter were those of the **Cabiri**, whose cult center was associated with the island of Samothrace and the city of Pergamum. The Cabiri themselves were usually referred to as *theoi megaloi*, the "great gods." Sometimes they were identified with the Dioscuri, Castor and Pollux, and thus offered protection from the dangers of seafaring. The Argonauts were said to have been initiated, and there are innumerable records of actual initiations in the Greek and Roman world right down until the end of the fourth century.¹⁵

The Persian Mithras. Three Eastern mystery religions widely practiced in the Roman Empire were sometimes assimilated to Greek and Roman mythology. From Persia came the mysteries of Mithras (or Mithra), the god of light and truth and righteous champion of good against evil. His myth included a miraculous birth from a rock and the slaying of a bull, from whose blood sprang the fertility of the earth. Mithraism was practiced in underground chapels or *Mithraea*. More

than four hundred of these have been found all over the Roman world, wherever Roman soldiers and merchants traveled. Basic to the iconography of a Mithraeum was a **tauroctony**, a scene depicting Mithras, amidst other figures, killing a bull, presumably a ritualistic sacrifice by which the god assured beneficence and rebirth for his initiates.¹⁶ The cult appealed especially to officers, soldiers, and sailors; and only men could be initiated. We do not know the details of the initiation rituals, but we do know that there were seven grades of initiation and that the cult demanded a high level of self-discipline from its initiates. Its ceremonies also involved a communal meal. Mithraism was a major rival to Christianity; and, like the other mystery religions we have mentioned, it continued to be practiced widely until the end of the fourth century.



Dea Syria and Other Syrian Cults. The second Eastern religion, which was not strictly a mystery religion with the usual elements of secrecy and revelation, was the worship of Atargatis, known to the Romans simply as Dea Syria, the Syrian goddess. She was originally an earth mother, like Cybele and Demeter, whose cult was spread through the Roman world, especially by soldiers. Shrines have been found at Rome itself and as far away as Hadrian's Wall, which the Romans built in northern England. Her consort was variously called Tammuz or Dushara, but her sacred marriage to the Semitic god of the thunder, Hadad, led to her association with the other sky-gods, the Syrian Baal, the Greek Zeus, and the Roman Jupiter. She was worshiped in wild rituals with self-flagellation by ecstatic priests.¹⁷ Among Romans, her consort was usually called Jupiter Dolichenus, who was portrayed holding an axe and a thunderbolt and standing on the back of a bull.¹⁸

Mithras Killing the Bull.

Marble relief, second century A.D. In this side of the double-sided relief, Mithras plunges his long dagger into the bull's throat. The bull's tail changes into ears of wheat, and below are a scorpion, a snake, and a dog. In the medallions above are the sun (to the left) and the moon. (Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY)

The Egyptian Isis. The third Eastern mystery religion is the worship of the Egyptian goddess Isis, and we have a full account of an initiate's conversion. Like Demeter and Cybele, Isis was a goddess of fertility, bringer of new life and hope. Her myth involved a search, in this case for her husband and brother, **Osiris** (dismembered by the evil power, Seth),¹⁹ and for a child, Horus (also known as Harpocrates). Her attributes included a musical instrument (the *sistrum*, a kind of rattle), a breast-shaped container (the *situla*) for milk, and a jug for the holy water of the Nile. Her cult was associated with the god **Serapis**, whose origin is quite obscure; temples to Isis and Serapis are found all over the Roman world. Isis herself, however, as mother and nurturer, appealed to multitudes of men and women, who found in her a less terrible presence than that of Cybele or the Syrian goddess. Lucius, the hero of Apuleius' novel *Metamorphoses* (or *The Golden Ass*), appealed to her for help in becoming a human being again and shedding his form as a donkey. She appeared to him in a dream and instructed him to take the garland of roses from the hand of a priest, who would be taking part in the procession in her honor the next day. When Lucius did this,

he resumed his human form, and the miracle was greeted with the praise of the crowd (*Metamorphoses* 11. 16):

The august divinity of the all-powerful goddess today has restored this man to human form. Fortunate indeed and thrice blessed is he who has deserved such glorious protection from heaven because of the innocence of his earlier life and faith.

The Syncretism of the Goddesses

When Isis first appeared to Lucius in answer to his prayer, she described herself in terms that perfectly illustrate the meaning of syncretism, expressed with a power and enthusiasm that even translation cannot totally obliterate (*Metamorphoses* 11. 5):

Behold, Lucius, I have come, moved by your prayers. I am the mother of things in nature, the mistress of all the elements, the firstborn of the ages, the sum of the divine powers, queen of the souls of the dead, first of the heavenly powers, the single form of the gods and goddesses, who by my nod control the bright heights of heaven, the health-bringing winds of the sea, the grievous silence of the gods of the Underworld. My name, one with many forms, varied rituals, and many names, is revered by the whole world. Thus the firstborn Phrygians call me Pessinuntia, the Mother of the Gods; the autochthonous people of Attica call me Cecropian Minerva; the Cyprians, tossed by the waves, call me Paphian Venus; the archer Cretans call me Dictynna Diana; the Sicilians of three languages call me Stygian Proserpina; the Eleusinians the ancient goddess Ceres; some call me Juno, others Bellona, some Hecate, others Rhamnusia [i.e., Nemesis]; the . . . Ethiopians . . . and the . . . Egyptians, who worship me with proper ceremonies, call me by my true name, Queen Isis. 10

Cybele, Athena, Aphrodite, Artemis, Demeter, Persephone, Hera—the ancient Queens of Heaven and Earth—are here, through the process of syncretism, included in the great Egyptian goddess, Isis. Apuleius, whose evidence is almost certainly reliable, shows us how in the second century (he was born about A.D. 120) the figures of Greek and Roman mythology had given way to the idea of a single divine power. Her devotees experienced a sense of liberation, of hope and joy. Lucius (through whom Apuleius is evidently describing his own experience) was initiated three times into the mysteries of Isis and Serapis; his life was consecrated to Isis. In this experience, we can see how the mythology of the gods of the Greek city-state became incorporated in the mysteries that brought hope of salvation to the individual worshiper. The power of that experience is revealed in Lucius' description, with which we end our survey of the mystery religions (*Metamorphoses* 11. 23):

Perhaps you may ask, studious reader, what then was said, what was done. I would tell you, if it were lawful to speak; and you would know, if it were lawful to hear. . . . I do not wish to torture you . . . with the pain of long suspense. Therefore hear, but believe, because these things are true. I approached the boundaries of death; I trod the entrance of Proserpina and, carried through all the elements, I returned. At midnight I saw the sun shining with brilliant light,

I came into the presence of the gods below and the gods above, and close by I worshiped them. Behold, I have told you that about which, although you have heard, you must remain ignorant.

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 Vergil *Georgics* 4.315–566 (Aristaeus and his bees)

Notes

1. One of the many places identified as an entrance to the Underworld was a cave near Taenarus, a town in Laconia.
2. Aristaeus, the son of Apollo and Cyrene, is the traditional hero or deity of rustic pursuits, especially beekeeping. When Eurydice died, her sister Dryads in their grief and anger caused all the bees of Aristaeus to die. Perplexed by this action, he eventually consulted the wise old man of the sea, Proteus. Aristaeus appeased the nymphs, and a new swarm of bees was created. Through the role of Aristaeus, Vergil artfully introduces the touching account of Orpheus and Eurydice in the last book of his didactic poem on farming.
3. An important survey offers the general reader a scholarly examination of the whole question: W. K. C. Guthrie, *Orpheus and Greek Religion: A Study of the Orphic Movement* (New York: Norton, 1966).

4. He does not seem really to belong, but the gentle bard was placed among the brawny heroes because of his prestige and the magical powers of his song, which saved them all in more than one crisis. Orpheus appropriately was the leader in religious matters. The chronology also seems wrong for our historical Orpheus, if we must put him back in the heroic age in the generation before the Trojan War.
5. The chronological tradition for Orpheus is equally muddled. Those who connect his dates with Homer's deserve the most credibility. Thus either he was the inventor of writing and his works immediately preceded the Homeric epics, or Homer was the first poet and Orpheus followed shortly after.
6. This link with Dionysus may mean that Orpheus is yet another god (however faded) of the death and rebirth of vegetation; Eurydice, too, has some of the chthonian characteristics of Semele and Persephone. These parallels could likewise have been added to the legend that grew up about a historical prophet. Some of the themes also look like motifs common to folktale: conjugal devotion, the journey to Hades' realm, the taboo of looking back.
7. The words of the Composer, yet another Orpheus (*Musik ist eine heilige Kunst . . .*), in the opera *Ariadne auf Naxos*, by Richard Strauss and Hugo von Hofmannsthal, which epitomizes the profundity of Orpheus' art in one of the most beautiful of all musical motifs.
8. The date and authorship of these hymns are not securely established; perhaps at least some of them are earlier. See Apostolos N. Athanassakis, *The Orphic Hymns*, text, translation, and notes (Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1977); Athanassakis (pp. viii–ix) inclines to accept the theories of Otto Kern that the hymns belong to the city of Pergamum for use in the celebration of the mysteries of Dionysus, third century A.D.
9. An attractive thesis claims that the religion attributed to the legendary musician was formulated in large part by philosophers in southern Italy and Sicily (although not necessarily confined to this region) in the sixth century B.C. Thus we can explain the elements identified as Orphic in the philosophy of Empedocles and in the religious sect of Pythagoras and thereby account for the Orphic–Pythagorean thought transmitted by Plato.
10. See Aristophanes' parody translated on pp. 61–62.
11. See E. R. Dodds, *The Greeks and the Irrational* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1951) and I. Lewis, *Ecstatic Religion, a Study of Shamanism and Spirit Possession*, 3d ed. (New York: Routledge, 2003 [1971]).
12. For the archetypal Orpheus and subsequent motifs, including that of the Good Shepherd, see John Block Friedman, *Orpheus in the Middle Ages* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1970).
13. The Roman emperor Augustus himself was initiated, while Nero, according to his biographer Suetonius, did not dare to become a candidate because of his guilty conscience. In the third century A.D., Gallienus (253–268) commemorated his initiation by issuing a coin with his name and title in the feminine gender (*Galliena Augusta*) in honor of the goddess.
14. The *taurobolium* is described in detail by the fourth-century Christian poet Prudentius in the tenth of his hymns about martyrs, *Peri Stephanon* (*On Crowns*). The most vivid details are translated in John Ferguson, *Religions of the Roman Empire* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1970), pp. 104–105. The *taurobolium*, which is recorded in many inscriptions, the first being in A.D. 105, was practiced by initiates of Mithraism and even of Demeter; for a description by Frazer in connection with the worship of Attis, see pp. 200–201.
15. See Susan Cole, *Theoi Megaloi: The Cult of the Great Gods of Samothrace* (Leiden, The Netherlands: Brill, 1984).
16. This interpretation, advocated by Franz Cumont, *The Mysteries of Mithra* (New York: Dover, 1956 [1903]), has been challenged. David Ulansey, *The Origins of the Mithraic Mysteries* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1989), follows those scholars who

believe the tauroctony represents a series of stars and constellations, and in this kind of star map, the figure of Mithras is to be equated with the Greek and Roman Perseus.

17. Vividly described by Apuleius, *Metamorphoses* 8. 27–29.
18. To this Jupiter, the Romans assimilated the dedications of the great temples of Baal at Baalbek (in modern Lebanon), usually referred to as the temple of Jupiter and of Bel at Palmyra.
19. See R. E. Witt, *Isis in the Greek and Roman World* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1997 [1971]). For Io, who came to be worshiped as Isis, see pp. 98–99 and 547–548.

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PART TWO

The Greek Sagas



The Judgment of Paris, mosaic from Antioch

PART TWO

The Greek Sagas

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Introduction to the Greek Sagas

Universal themes are persistent in the myths of Greek gods, who present archetypal images of fundamental human traits—the passions, psychology, and mores of mortal men and women writ large—and basic familial relationships, social ties, and political aspirations. Variations of these recurring themes are equally prominent in saga (or legend) and folktale. These classes of myth have been discussed in Chapter 1 (p. 4), and saga will be the principal focus of the chapters in this part. Although saga has a relationship (however tenuous) to history, it often includes elements of folktale that are common to other legends, and its heroes are descended from gods and often associate with divine beings. A defining feature of saga is the focus upon the deeds of one or more heroes.

The Hero and Heroine in Saga and Folktale

We have seen (pp. 13–14) how the Russian scholar Vladimir Propp has shown how one particular kind of folktale (the Quest) has a universal structure, in which the elements always appear in the same sequence. In Greek saga, as in folktales, we find many recurring motifs, though not always as predictably as in Propp's structural theory. Ten motifs frequently appear: (1) The hero usually has elements of the extraordinary linked to his birth and his childhood. (2) He inevitably faces opposition of one sort or another from the beginning, and as a result he must prove his inherent worth by surmounting challenges of every kind. (3) His enemy or enemies usually instigate his achievement, and (4) he is helped by at least one ally, divine or human. (5) He faces apparently insuperable obstacles, often labors that must be accomplished or a quest that must be completed. (6) Adventurous conflicts with divine, human, or monstrous opponents present him with physical, sexual, and spiritual challenges. (7) He may also have to observe taboos—he must not, for example, look back, eat of a forbidden fruit, or be too inquisitive. (8) Death itself is the ultimate conquest, usually achieved by going to and returning from the Underworld. (9) The hero's success may be rewarded with marriage, political security, or wealth and power. (10) But knowledge through suffering and more lasting spiritual enlightenment (literal or symbolic)—entailing purification, rebirth, redemption, and even deification—are also part of a hero's attainment. These and other motifs recur with seemingly infinite variation, and they will continue to do so as long as human nature remains the same. Refined by artistic experience, they delight and inform, while they touch the very depths of the human spirit.

Propp's analysis of structure is very helpful for the scientific mythographer interested in structural analysis and similarities in the patterns of comparative mythology. It can be very misleading, however, for those whose delight is in the study of the subtle differences in the manipulation of motifs and the diverse characterization of heroes in all periods of mythological creation. The quests of Perseus, Odysseus, and Aeneas, to name only three, are to some degree alike, but they are all the more fascinating because of their differences. Achilles and Ajax represent two very different personalities in their response to the thematic code of heroic *arete* (excellence). Hector and Paris are not simple reflections of the pattern of brotherly opposites; instead, emotionally and psychologically they are worlds apart, and their feelings about war, life and death, and love and marriage



Greece and Asia Minor.

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